

A WIN-WIN SITUATION

According to Sanjog Gupta, Head-Sports at Disney Star, nothing unites audiences across the country like cricket. The fact that the IPL is watched by an audience of more than 600 million between television and digital bears testimony to that. "Its capacity to aggregate viewers at such scale in a short burst of time combined with the intense engagement it delivers renders it unique. The expanse of that aggregation is unlike anything else, including cinema," he says.

Cricket serves both tactical and commercial objectives due to short bursts of aggregation and engagement as well as strategic intent, given its ability to recruit audiences and facilitate the building of a portfolio, platform or business on top of it. "One can build a robust business model around a core proposition that cricket helps build," says Gupta.

40 | Lloyd Mathias, business strategist and former marketing head of PepsiCo India, Motorola and HP Asia-Pacific, believes IPL has managed the unique feat of being a win-win for all seven parties—players, audiences, team owners, businesses, media companies, BCCI and Indian cricket. "Players who bagged a single-season contract were suddenly making more money than they did after playing 10 years of domestic cricket. Of course, one great season for the player [also] means attention from the national selectors," says Mathias. For audiences, the IPL was a chance to see world-class cricketers competing fiercely with their favourite local stars in a glamourised version of the sport. "Team owners got financial benefits that were not initially apparent. Today, each of the original franchises has easily made a 25x return [in terms of valuation] on its original investment, with other benefits and bragging rights," he adds.

As for the BCCI, 50 per cent of the revenues from the sale of IPL media rights go into its coffers, with the rest going to the teams, while Indian cricket is rewarded with talent that otherwise might not have been spotted. Businesses—advertisers, sponsors, and their ilk—have also found their association with the sport beneficial, while for media companies, cricket gets them the eyeballs (more on that later).

At this year's IPL, JioCinema, Viacom18's OTT platform, disrupted the status quo by streaming the tournament free of cost. "We provided unrestricted access to anyone who wanted to watch it in a frictionless manner without a paywall or subscription," says Anil Jayaraj, CEO at Viacom18 Sports. One more component of the strategy, says Jayaraj, was for the audience to watch it in cohorts, which led to

17 simultaneous feeds across 12 languages including English, Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Tamil, Bhojpuri and Odia. "Long-form content on digital is a reality today, and with 700 million internet users in India, a lot can be done."

THE SMELL OF MONEY

Streaming the IPL free on JioCinema means advertising will be the only source of revenue for the company. But some say that advertising during cricket tournaments is an expensive proposition. For instance, in 2017, a 10-second IPL spot went for ₹6.5 lakh; now it is as high as ₹17-18 lakh. Are they worth the expense? Mathias says the tournament provides a highly engaged audience due to the high-intensity games. "The visibility on television can cause a surge in immediate interest as well as brand recall at a later stage. Besides, cricket, as a sport, is immensely advertiser-friendly, with spots after every over, every wicket and numerous breaks." But for advertisers, can cricket deliver? "To say nothing can deliver as much as cricket is not correct. The question is, how much the advertiser needs to spend to get to that reach," says Mayank Shah, Senior Category Head at Parle Products. He admits that cricket does bring a larger audience than the largest general entertainment



There is no plan to charge a subscription fee for sports... We have done well on digital advertising during this IPL and believe there is still a very large opportunity"

ANIL JAYARAJ
CEO, Viacom18 Sports



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